

9.9.2026 Public Comment

Good evening. My name is Monica Strauser, and I am a Kennett Township resident.

Over the last several months, I've spent a lot of time talking about the proposed police facility.

Tonight, I want to step back and talk about the bigger issue: taxes.

Kennett Township residents already carry a significant municipal tax burden.

Our property tax is now 3.7 mills.

Compare that with New Garden at 3.27 mills, Pocopson at 2.2, Newlin at 2.1, West Marlborough at 2.0, and Pennsbury at just 1.49.

East Marlborough is now higher, at 4.883 mills.

But property taxes aren't the whole story.

Kennett residents also pay a 1% earned income tax, plus another quarter-percent earned income tax dedicated to open space.

New Garden's open-space tax is half of ours. And several of our other neighboring townships have significantly lower earned-income-tax rates.

So no, Kennett isn't the highest in every individual category.

But taken together, we are already a relatively highly taxed township compared with many of our neighbors.

And I think that makes the attitude toward additional tax increases particularly important.

Because I increasingly hear tax increases discussed here as though they are simply the natural solution when the Township wants to spend more money.

I don't think they should be.

Kennett Township is not a stagnant community with a shrinking tax base.

We are growing — substantially.

Rosedale is adding 72 homes.

Parkside is adding 183 residential units, plus commercial space.

Kennett Pointe is adding another 77 residential units and more than 16,000 square feet of retail.

That's **332 new residential units**, plus new commercial development.

Those developments will generate new revenue.

So I think residents deserve an answer to a very basic question:

Where is the money from all of this growth going?

I'm not suggesting that growth has no costs. Of course it does.

But show us the numbers.

How much additional property-tax revenue will these developments generate when they're fully built?

How much additional earned-income-tax revenue do we expect from hundreds of new households?

What are the additional costs attributable to that growth?

And what is the net benefit to the Township?

Because if we're adding hundreds of taxpayers and commercial properties, and that still isn't enough to help fund our priorities without repeatedly raising tax rates, residents deserve to understand why.

More importantly, before asking us for more money, I want to know what this Board and administration are doing to **avoid** tax increases.

Where is the public discussion about constraining spending?

Where are the alternatives?

Where is the examination of different service models?

Where are the efforts to generate revenue from assets we already own?

Could Fussell House be rented or sold?

Could our recreational facilities generate additional revenue?

Could we negotiate services regionally?

Are there functions we could share with neighboring municipalities?

These are the conversations I want to hear before the conversation becomes: **How much should we raise taxes?**

Because from a resident's perspective, it is sometimes difficult to understand what we're receiving in exchange for this relatively high municipal tax burden.

We don't have municipal trash collection or even a Township-negotiated trash rate.

We don't have curbside yard-waste pickup.

Residents complain repeatedly about speeding, yet getting even relatively inexpensive traffic-calming measures implemented seems extraordinarily difficult.

And on top of all of this, we have chosen one of the most expensive services a small municipality can provide independently: our own police department.

That isn't inherently wrong.

But it is a choice.

And choices have costs.

Police salaries increase. Pensions increase. Equipment costs increase. Vehicles need replacement.

And now we're considering millions of dollars in new construction that will create decades of additional operating, maintenance and capital costs.

Last year, this Board approved a 0.1-mill tax increase while discussing a financial plan that contemplates additional 0.1-mill increases over seven years.

I have a fundamental problem with that approach.

The Township says no final decision has been made about this project.

If that's true, then residents shouldn't simultaneously be told to expect years of incremental tax increases to generate the revenue needed to pay for it.

Seven small tax increases are still a large tax increase.

I want this Board to demonstrate the same creativity in **avoiding tax increases** that it has demonstrated in figuring out how to finance this building.

And there is a very relevant example just down the road.

Oxford Borough faced escalating police costs.

Their response wasn't simply, "raise taxes."

They spent years studying their finances and evaluating alternatives to future tax increases.

They examined maintaining their department. They examined a hybrid model. And they examined regional policing.

Last month, Oxford made a difficult decision and voted to join the Southern Chester County Regional Police Department.

And here's the important part:

Oxford residents aren't losing local policing.

They will continue to have 24-hour coverage.

Two officers will still be assigned to patrol Oxford.

They will have a staffed police substation in Oxford and local supervisory presence.

But they will also gain the resources and economies of scale of a regional department.

I'm not standing here tonight saying Kennett Township must make the same decision Oxford made.

I'm asking you to demonstrate that you're willing to ask the same questions.

What services do residents actually need?

What level of service can we afford?

What can we share regionally?

What assets can generate revenue?

Where can we reduce costs?

And most importantly:

How do we accomplish our priorities without continually reaching into residents' pockets for more money?

Before this Board approves another tax increase associated with the municipal expansion, please have that conversation publicly.

Show us what you've done to constrain costs.

Show us the alternatives you've considered.

Show us the additional revenue our growth is generating.

And then show us why that isn't enough.

Tax increases should be the last option considered — not the first assumption built into the plan.

Thank you.